TRACTOR TYCOON

Mallika Srinivasan, *64*
Chairperson & Managing Director, Tractors & Farm Equipment Limited (TAFE)



AFP

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Led by technology, she has transformed TAFE into the country's second largest farm equipment producer and the world's third largest tractor manufacturer with a turnover of over Rs 10,000 crore

BORN TO ACE INDUSTRIALIST A. Sivasailam in 1959, Mallika Srinivasan never took her privilege for granted. A University of Madras and Wharton School of Business alumna, she joined the family business in 1986, leading a major technology-driven transformation at Tractors and Farm Equipment Limited, known by its acronym TAFE. Besides turning the Chennai-headquartered agricultural machinery manufacturer into a mass producer of tractors, she has diversified its interests into various sectors, including diesel engines, generators, engineering plastics, hydraulic pumps and cylinders, automobile franchises and plantations.

TAFE, with Mallika at the helm, has made major acquisitions in recent years. Like the Rs 400 crore deal to buy French firm Faurecia's India business in 2022, and the iconic Serbian tractor brand Industrija Masina i Traktora (Industry of Machinery and Tractors) earlier in 2018. Today, TAFE is the world's third-largest tractor manufacturer and India's second-largest farm equipment manufacturer. (Husband Venu Srinivasan-led TVS Motor, meanwhile, has the third largest market share among two-wheeler brands in India.)

"There was no pressure on either me or my sister to enter the family business," says Mallika. "My parents made sure I received a good education. Once I joined TAFE, all my father said was that I should make a success of whatever I do...and that I must grow." Ask her what women need to succeed, and she is candid. "The elements of success are the same, whether you are a man or a woman. Manufacturing and selling cosmetics must be just as difficult as manufacturing and selling tractors," she says. Her instinct for marketing, in fact, prompts her to listen and respect the end-users; so she stops at tea shops and engages in conversations with locals while travelling through the countryside.

Beyond coping with corporate challenges, Mallika holds positions on the global board of the US-India Business Council and the boards of the US-based giant AGCO Corporation, which has a joint venture with TAFE, and various academic and business entities in India. In 2021, she became the first person from the private sector to be appointed head of the Public Enterprises Selection Board, responsible for appointments to top management positions in the government sector.

Committed to giving back to society, she also supports the eyecare institution, Sankara Nethralaya, and the Cancer Institute, both in Chennai, and contributes to educational and healthcare facilities in Alwarkurichi in TN's Tirunelveli district. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon

MATTER OF FACT

"The elements of success are the same, whether you are a man or a woman, whether you are in automobiles, engineering or retail"

PATRON OF THE ARTS Promotes Carnatic music through the Indira Sivasailam Foundation